percent of its imports were trade within the region.[66] This will increase further with new trade agreements. The Comprehensive and Progressive Agreement for Trans-Pacific Partnership (CPATPP), a multilateral free trade agreement formerly known as the Trans-Pacific Partnership (TPP), was signed in March 2018 despite US withdrawal.[67] Although India recently decided to withdraw from the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership (RCEP)[68] negotiations, the RCEP is expected to be finalised soon, casting a shadow on India's ability to act as a counterforce to China in Asia.[69] Meanwhile, talks for a free trade agreement between China, Japan, and South Korea are gathering momentum.[70]

The BRI could well have constituted an organising basis for Asian solidarity and cohesion but has fallen short of this expectation, as it is seen as Sinocentric and as a vehicle for China to rebalance its economy and use its surpluses of funding, labour, and materials to develop its hinterland and to invest in partner countries. All the proposed linkages, those of the Silk Road Economic Belt through Eurasia and the 21st Century Maritime Silk Road from East Asia to Europe and beyond, emerge from and end in China. Instead of framing it as "One Belt, One Road" (OBOR), as the Chinese government did at the outset in 2013, the project might have had greater potential framed as "One Belt, Many Roads," recognising that other Asian countries too have ties of commerce and culture along traditional routes. Moreover, there is now a concern in partner countries that the BRI leads not to public goods and interdependence but to growing economic dependence on China, including through becoming indebted to China.[71]

Despite its reservations towards the BRI, India has participated in setting up the Asian Infrastructure and Investment Bank (AIIB), which was specifically devised to promote connectivity and integration in Asia in cooperation with existing multilateral development banks. India joined 21